

MUJEEB KHAN

in his house. Other households, most of them in a low-lying area, report a similar plight.

Part of the semi-arid geography of the Bundelkhand region, Mahoba saw the number of years with deficient rainfall per decade shoot up from three to seven between 1972-81 and 1992-2001. A mostly rocky sub-surface adds to its woes. So, whatever rain it does receive fails to percolate down deep enough to form perennial aquifers that can be relied on during the dry months.

It was keeping in mind the region's urgent need for water that UP chief minister Yogi Adityanath launched the first phase of the Har Ghar Jal scheme on June 30, 2020, from Bundelkhand, with 2022 as the deadline. It was part of the larger Jal Jeevan Mission that Prime Minister Narendra Modi had announced on August 15, 2019, to provide safe and adequate drinking water through individual tap connections to all households in rural India by 2024.

But there is clearly a wide chasm between intention and implementation. At Lamora village, which like Bachhechhar Khurd is located in Mahoba's Jaitpur block, 40-year-old Ganpat Ahirwar, a farmer by occupation, cites the example of his own house and of several others in at least three neighbouring lanes where water pipelines, forget taps, are still awaited. In fact, per the JJM dashboard, of the 434 villages in Mahoba, only 183 have been certified as having attained 'Har Ghar Jal' status—that is, their respective gram sabhas have passed a resolution after ascertaining the claim of the water supply department that all households are getting tap water.

GROUND REPORT

- **Government claims to have installed taps in 97.6 per cent of rural households in Mahoba district in Bundelkhand, which is the highest coverage under the Har Ghar Jal scheme across UP**
- **Despite that, many villagers complain of not getting water from their taps; even pipelines are awaited at many places**
- **In fact, per the Jal Jeevan Mission data, only 183 of the 434 villages in Mahoba have been certified as having attained 'Har Ghar Jal' status**

Ask senior officials in the state headquarters, and they will tell you that it is a short-term lapse—all shortcomings will be rectified by November-end. "We are implementing the scheme in three stages," says Anurag Srivastava, principal secretary of the Namami Gange and rural water supply department. The first stage, he says, entails the laying of pipelines and installation of taps besides electrical and mechanical works. Then comes the 'commissioning', that is, bringing water from the source via treatment plants to fill the village water tanks. The third and final step is to supply water to each house and certify that the village has attained 'Har Ghar Jal' status.

"The first two stages have almost been completed in every village," says Srivastava. "But in some villages in Mahoba, we have received complaints that the contractors have not carried out proper work in the commissioning stage. We are in the process of penalising them." By the end of November, he reassures, all three stages will be completed in "most of the villages".

Sanjay Singh, a water conservationist based in Jhansi, admits that any project being implemented on such a scale is bound to face challenges. "What's important is to prepare the community for the change," he says. "Water literacy should begin in schools. The government should also focus on replenishing groundwater."

Many villagers, for example, remain apprehensive about the quality of water that they have started receiving, using it for just bathing and washing clothes. Zubair Beg, additional district magistrate, Namami Gange, Mahoba, claims that many times, villagers mistake chlorinated water as being contaminated. "When we tour the villages, we drink the tap water to show the residents that it's safe," he says. "It's regularly tested too."

Amid the overwhelming sentiment of delay and misgiving, there are some who do consider the scheme a godsend for the region. Rama Devi, 46, of Shivahar village, for instance, recalls the time when she had to walk miles to fetch water from distant wells. With water now being supplied to her home, she can utilise the time she saves to engage in other pursuits, such as stitching and embroidery or lend a hand in the fields. She hopes that this becomes a reality for every rural household not just in Mahoba but across Bundelkhand. ■